

Unit 3 – Section 1: Business Objectives & Strategy

Exam Patterns & Trends (2019 – 2025)

Overview of Exam Patterns

Mark Type	Typical Command Words	Frequency of Appearance	Focus Areas
4 marks	Calculate / Explain / Construct	Every Paper	Business model definitions or short applications (e.g. “Explain one aim of portfolio analysis”)
8 marks	Assess	Every Paper	Two-point balanced analysis tasks (e.g. usefulness of a model, impact of a strategy)
12 marks	Discuss	Every Paper	Strategy choice and justification with balance and evaluation (e.g. “Discuss whether cost leadership is sustainable”)
20 marks	Evaluate	Every Paper	Extended evaluation of models/strategic choices (e.g. “Evaluate how Porter’s Matrix guides strategy for X”)

AO Weighting: AO1 (20%), AO2 (25%), AO3 (25%), AO4 (30%)

Topic Trend Analysis (2019 – 2025)

Topic	Year & Question	Command Words	Key Trend Summary
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	Reference		
Mission Statements	2021 Jan Q1a, 2023 Jan Q1	Explain / Discuss	Often paired with objectives; short definition or link to strategy.
Corporate Objectives	2020 Jun Q1b, 2024 Oct Q1a	Assess / Evaluate	Commonly used in 8–20 mark tasks focusing on SMART or ethics vs profit.
Ansoff Matrix	2020 Jun Q2b, 2022 Jan Q1c, 2023 Oct Q2	Assess / Evaluate	Consistent appearance, often linked with risk or diversification.
Porter's Generic Strategies	2021 Oct Q3, 2022 Jun Q2	Discuss / Evaluate	Popular for 12–20 marks; focuses on competitive advantage.
Portfolio Analysis	2020 Jun Q1d, 2023 Jan Q1b	Explain / Assess	Appears as a 4–8 mark question; strategic resource allocation.
SWOT Analysis	2021 Jun Q1a, 2023 Jun Q2a	Explain / Assess	Mid-mark questions on usefulness or limitations.
PESTLE Analysis	2019 Oct Q2a, 2022 Jan Q2c	Assess / Evaluate	Linked to strategy formulation; frequent in 20-mark evaluation.
Porter's Five Forces	2020 Jun Q3, 2024 Jun Q2	Discuss / Evaluate	A recurring 20-mark theme on competition or profitability.

Predicted Focus for Jan 2026 Exam

Predicted Topic	Mark	Command Word	Likely Context
Mission & Corporate	8	Assess	Assess how mission

Objectives			statements and objectives guide strategic decisions at Apple.
Ansoff Matrix	12	Discuss	Discuss whether diversification is always a high-risk strategy.
Porter's Generic Strategies	20	Evaluate	Evaluate whether differentiation is a sustainable competitive strategy for Tesla.
Portfolio & SWOT	4	Explain	Explain one benefit of using portfolio analysis in strategic planning.
PESTLE & Porter's Five Forces	20	Evaluate	Evaluate whether external forces are more important than internal factors in determining long-term strategy.

Teacher Revision Tips

- Retrieval starters: definitions of all eight strategic models.
- Use “model match-up” tasks — give students real case data and ask which model fits.
- Run 12-mark timed essays (15 min) to build balance and mini-judgement skills.
- 20-mark workshops: focus on AO4 evaluation using “depends on” and time horizon.
- Encourage use of businesses like Apple, Dyson, Tesco, Starbucks, Aldi, Patagonia for contextual links.

Summary of Key Insights

- Every paper features at least one model from Section 1.
- Porter's Five Forces and Ansoff Matrix are high-frequency 20-mark questions.

- AO4 (evaluation) continues to dominate the top-level questions.
- Recent papers blend internal (SWOT) and external (PESTLE, Five Forces) frameworks.